Sword of Etheria

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Sword of Etheria

by Lithos_Maitreya

Summary

She-Ra has existed for uncountable millennia, has fought armies, monsters, kings, wizards, and gods to a standstill. She has proven her existence in the eyes of the Logic.

What is Despondos, anyway?

Notes

DeltaFell's excellent Forever and a Blade ended just a few days ago. I started work on this idea before I even encountered the series, but I can't deny a certain similarity in concept. I highly recommend it for anyone who, like me, really wants to put the thematic fabric of SPOP against the backdrop of the titanic philosophical war of Destiny.

This story is complete. I will be uploading the chapters every day or two, unless I find a catastrophic issue in my final editing passes. (This has happened twice already--whole swathes of this story have been rewritten multiple times as I iterated on the plot.)

Fair warning if the tags didn't clue you in: we're going to some dark places, especially in the first couple of chapters. The universe of Destiny is not a kind or a pretty one, but it can be just... if we make it so.

If you enjoy the way I address the Destiny universe, I am currently writing a quest on Sufficient Velocity called Sword of Paradise. For the uninitiated, a quest is a type of story, typically written on a forum or a designated live platform like fiction.live, wherein the author writes a unit of the story (such as a chapter) and then prompts the readers for input as to what happens next. Once they get that input, they account

for it in the next chapter. Anyone interested is more than welcome to participate in Sword of Paradise.

Sorrow

Mara gasped for breath, watching as the planet crumbled around her. She felt She-Ra's power humming under her skin, begging for release, surging with the combined might of a planet.

Mara had hoped that, once she put down the sword, Light Hope would stop sending the activation signal. Wishful thinking—Light Hope was no longer thinking like a person, no longer weighing the costs against the benefits of anything she was doing. She was just a cog in Eternia's machine, now. She had been ordered to fire the Heart, and she would act to do so for as long as she was able. Even if it shook the very planet apart.

There was no way out. Mara sank to her knees on the floor of her ship. She had been trapped in this destiny from the moment she had been chosen to wield the Sword of Protection. She had tried to fight it, tried everything she could think of to reject the fate her people had made for her. It didn't matter.

The Heart of Etheria would fire. The universe would be wiped clean of Eternia's enemies—and of any innocent people who hadn't been fortunate enough to be protected. The peoples of a million worlds who had not yet reached the stars would all die. A thousand independent polities would be wiped away. Just collateral damage in the war to destroy the Hive.

There was nothing left to do.

If only… If only there was something, *anything*, she could do to stop the Heart. This was all her fault—she had laid the groundwork for the Heart, she had brought Light Hope here, she had let this happen. It was her responsibility to fix, and she couldn't.

She wished she could.

Your wish is sustenance, O Heroine mine.

Suddenly, the idea came to her, a flash of brilliant insight. She-Ra was a being of profound age and incredible power. She had fought armies to a standstill. She had beaten back Xivu Arath in open combat. She had razed war-moons and brood worlds to the ground.

By the sword-logic of the Hive, she had proven her right to exist. By their very logic… she should have a space carved for her in the Ascendant Plane, just like their gods did.

Despondos. The name popped into her head alongside a sense of desperate sorrow. It wasn't the first time She-Ra had bubbled up from within her like this, but it would be the last. It would take a massive expenditure of energy for Mara to move the entirety of Etheria into the Ascendant Plane. It would cost her everything. But she had to try.

She-Ra and Mara, together, reached out and *Took* the entirety of Etheria.

Catra pulled the lever.

The world reorganized, like a jigsaw puzzle being scrambled.

But Adora was not moved. She watched, wide-eyed, as the pieces that assembled Etheria were restructured into new forms. But the fabric of reality remained unchanged. And, somehow, she remained anchored to it, a fixed point, an absolute frame of reference in a relativistic universe.

You are dead, young She-Ra.

It all happened between one blink and the next, and then she was alone in the portal chamber. There was no portal. There was no Catra. There was no Hordak, no Glimmer, no Shadow Weaver. Just Adora.

But she could feel the planet coming apart. The sense was not a new one, but she had never been aware of it before. She could

feel the net holding Etheria within this universe coming apart at the seams, and she knew instinctively that something had to give. And it would not be the universe.

One shaking hand came up to clutch her head. A million thoughts were swirling around between her ears, and only a fraction of them felt like hers.

There is only one path and that is the path that you make.

Adora turned and left the room. *I have to find the sword,* she told herself over the cacophony in her skull. *I have to take the sword out of the portal. That will destabilize the portal, bring us back. I can still fix this.*

"Hey, Adora!" A voice, achingly familiar, agonizingly sweet, devoid of hate, anger, hurt. Adora turned. Catra was waving at her from down the hall. "Come on!" Catra said, a laugh on her lips and joy practically bursting from under her skin. "We've got training in a few minutes! The others are already waiting for us!"

Adora stared at her for a moment. *I think joy and sorrow will be the same thing soon.* The words almost rose to her tongue, but she swallowed them down. *Like love and death.*

The smile on Catra's lips shrank. "Adora?"

"I can't stay."

The smile vanished. "What?"

Adora reached out to her with one hand, motes of light glittering on her fingertips (*reach out and take the stars for your own*). Then she let it fall. "I want to stay," she said. "But I can't. It's not who I am. And the more you claw at me and try to pull me back, the faster I'll be pulled away."

You must obey your nature forever.

Catra's eyes were wide, her slit pupils narrow as the blade of a razor. "Adora," she whispered. "Please. For once in your life—"

"No." Adora turned around them. Time bent in the world around her as Catra crossed the distance between them in what was subjectively several seconds, but from her objective frame of reference was no time at all. Claws dug into her sleeve.

"I won't let you leave," Catra growled, and now the fury, the raw hatred, was back. "Not this time. You're not leaving me behind again."

Adora reached up and gripped Catra's hand. The Force-Captain squeaked as she was gripped with a fraction of Adora's strength, as her hand was pulled away with a force that could have crushed bone. Adora met her oldest friend's eyes, saw the fear and confusion there. She wondered what her face looked like, now—cold and emotionless, perhaps? Or teary-eyed and hurt? Or both? "I never wanted to leave you," she said. "I stayed with you for ten years. I stayed with you even though it hurt, even though it made me hate myself, and you, and Shadow Weaver most of all, for what she put us through. I stayed with you no matter how hard it got—*because* it was hard. Because you were worth it."

Catra's pupils were dilated, now, wide enough that her heterochromia was only visible as rings of color around her wide pupils. "I—"

"When I finally found something I could not tolerate," Adora cut her off, "when I finally could not *stay*, I asked you to come with me. And *you refused*." She pulled her hand away. "You wanted me to choose you," Adora said. "I did, for ten years. I wanted to continue. But if it's you or the entire world? It doesn't *matter* what I would choose. The choice *isn't mine*." She turned away. "Goodbye, Catra."

She took a step forward, bending the fabric of the universe around her, and was gone. The Fright Zone faded behind her. The portal hung in the air above the Whispering Woods. The Sword

could not hide from her—not here, in this cyst-universe that belonged to her, this throne-world that was her kingdom.

She reached up and took it.

Everyone was staring at her as she stepped out of the portal. Almost lazily she swung the sword behind her, shattering the mechanism. Her eyes, almost unbidden, found Catra's. There were tears there. As their eyes met, Catra's hands pulled away from the lever as though burned, recoiling from her gaze like fire. "Adora…"

Adora's eyes slid closed. The voices were still there. She was awake, now. Her eyes were open, and she couldn't close them again. "Despondos," she murmured aloud.

Glimmer rushed to her side, Shadow Weaver tugged along behind her. "Adora, are you okay?"

Adora's eyes opened. She found the lights in Shadow Weaver's mask first, then looked down at Glimmer. "Okay…?" she asked slowly. "I'm… fine. I feel good."

"I knew you could do it," Shadow Weaver's voice slithered into her ears, putrid and sickly. "You were always destined for greatness, Adora—"

Shadow Weaver fell silent with a cough. Her eyes widened. So did Glimmer's, staring down at the sword embedded in Shadow Weaver's chest.

For a moment Adora was surprised at herself, but that faded quickly. "This is my world," she said, with all the certitude of fact. "My universe. And now I have ascended to the throne, there is no place for you in it."

She pulled the sword out. Shadow Weaver fell to her knees, staring up at her. "Adora—"

The sword swung. Shadow Weaver never spoke again.

Adora looked around at the horrified faces and knew. They would not—could not—understand. They would see a monster to be stopped, or a traumatized girl to be comforted. She was neither. Not anymore. Not now that she was awake. Her eyes turned on Hordak. His eyes widened. He took a step back.

It was the last step he ever took.

The room was silent for a moment, save for a soft sound. It took Adora a moment to realize it was Catra weeping.

Adora flicked her sword, the blood sliding off it like oil from water. Such was her will. Then she turned back to the room. "You can all remain here," she said. "Etheria can stay, here in my sword-world. You'll be safe. Nothing can enter here without my permission—not now that I man the borders again." She turned and swung her sword, cutting through air, space, and time. The wound in reality billowed before her, universe-flesh gaping and seeping smoky, black ichor.

"Where are you going?" The voice was Glimmer's, the words, whispered.

"Out," said Adora. "There's a whole universe of swords out there. They've forgotten me. It's time to remind them."

"You're not She-Ra." The voice was broken. Adora's gaze was drawn to Catra. Tears tracked down her face, horror and shame dragging her down like physical weights. "You're Adora. Please. Remember."

Adora considered that, then sighed and shook her head. "I was," She-Ra said. "Not anymore."

She turned and stepped through the hole. It closed behind her, leaving Despondos, and Etheria, safely sealed once more.

Hundreds of light-years away, a signal was caught by a sensor on a great capital-ship. Four green eyes gazed upon a screen. A smile

touched pale lips. “So that’s where you are, little brother.”

The Emperor of the Known Universe turned his gaze upon an empty patch of space in curiosity. What would he find there, he wondered.

Horde Prime set a course with all the confidence of a man who had never seen fire striding into an inferno. The Known Universe, he would soon find, was far smaller than he had realized.

Clinging to the *Velvet Glove*, its wings curled about it, a dragon tasted his desires and bared its many teeth in a smile.

Thousands of light-years away, three eyes opened, luminous with soulfire. Xivu Arath raised up her lumbering bulk and turned towards a distant galaxy, her eyes fixed on a point she could not see. Her worm screamed in jubilant rage.

Xivu Arath, war-god, had been beaten only once on the battlefield, save by her own brother, who was dead. One thing, a god like and yet unlike her, had stood against her, had crossed its sword with hers, and had survived, had beaten her back into her cyst-world. And when she emerged, that god had fled into its own hidden throne where Xivu Arath could not reach it.

For a millennium she had waited, distracting herself with other wars and lesser foes, sating the hunger of her worm with morsels. No longer.

The She-Ra had returned to the material world. Soon Xivu Arath would feast on her death.

That, or she would be wormfood herself.

Deep

Chapter Summary

> The Queen of Brightmoon interrogates her most reticent prisoner. Meanwhile, She-Ra meets the Emperor of the Known Universe.

Catra idly scratched doodles in the floor of her makeshift cell. Brightmoon, she had discovered, had no prison—only a spare bedroom that they repurposed with a magic barrier when they needed to. She would have laughed when she found out, if she had any laughter left in her.

The door opened. Catra's back was to it, and she didn't bother to turn around or acknowledge the intruder. She just kept running her claws through the stone, watching the masonry part—

—*space itself, parting like flesh*—

—She blinked away the image, then blinked again to wipe away the beginnings of tears forming. A throat cleared behind her. She hadn't heard that voice often before—it had seldom if ever graced the battlefield—but she recognized it nonetheless. "Force-Captain Catra," said Queen Angella stonily.

"You need something?" Catra asked, her voice languid.

"My daughter seems to think you have some insight into what happened in the Fright Zone," the Queen said. "You will tell me whatever you know."

Catra considered that for a moment. Then she rolled over onto her back, staring straight up so that the sparkly monarch was in her periphery. "Why?" she asked.

"Because if you don't, you're never seeing the outside of a cell again." Angella's voice was glacial.

"Don't really care," Catra said, and it was true.

A pause. Then Angella sighed. "What *do* you care about, then?" Angella asked. "What can I offer you to get you to speak?"

Catra's face twisted. She forced down the tears.

—I stayed with you for ten years—

"You can't give me what I want," Catra muttered.

"Don't discount me so easily," Angella said softly.

Catra blinked and looked at her properly. The Queen wasn't looking at her, but rather out the window at the dark night sky. "Adora's *gone*," she hissed.

—I asked you to come with me, and you—

"Unless you have a way to bring her back, you don't have anything I want."

"Even if I could find her out in the cosmos," Angella said dryly, "why on earth would I give her to you? I prefer my daughter's friends *not* ripped to shreds."

Catra bared her teeth—

—This is my world—

—and spat, "You don't know *anything* about me. Or about Adora. You just want your *weapon* back."

Angella finally turned to look at her. Her eyes were deep and sad. "I never saw Adora as a weapon," she said quietly. "None of the rebellion's fighters were just weapons to us. They were—are—people, with wants and needs and dreams. Do you know what I saw when I looked at Adora?" Catra didn't reply, but Angella continued anyway. "I saw a traumatized girl with the weight of the world on her shoulders. The only person in the rebellion who ever

saw Adora as a weapon and nothing more was Adora herself." The Queen's gaze hardened. "Tell me—where might she have gotten that impression?"

Catra's eyes widened—

—Blue eyes wide, staring at her behind a closing door as the pain mounted, as the red lightning grew ever brighter—

—and she reflexively dug a deep furrow into the stone with her claws. "So, what, it's *my* fault?" she growled. "My fault Adora was Shadow Weaver's favorite? My fault she was always getting all the attention? My fault that the moment things got hard, she *ran away—*"

—you refused.

Catra's voice cut off in a choked sound, and she frantically scrubbed at her eyes with the back of her hand, turning away from the Queen to hide what she had already seen.

There was silence for a few seconds. Then, "Please, Catra," said the Queen quietly. "Tell me what happened. If I'm to do anything for Adora, I need to know what happened to her."

"Ask your daughter," muttered Catra. "Or, what's his name, Arrows."

The Queen sighed. "Fine. One final question. Where is Princess Entrapta? She was not found when we explored the Fright Zone after the surrender."

"Beast Island," muttered Catra. "I sent her there because she was trying to stop the portal from opening. Lotta good that did me."

"Very well." Angella sounded tired. "My guards will bring you three meals a day. Let them know if you would like anything to read. If you ever feel like telling me more, I will listen. For now, I have an expedition to plan."

Catra blinked and looked up. “An expedition?”

“To Beast Island,” said the Queen as she turned away. “Entrapta is —was—a member of the Princess Alliance. We have to mount a rescue operation.”

“Beast Island is a *death sentence.*”

Angella shrugged, still without looking back. “Then I’d best gather my team quickly.”

The door began to swing shut. “Wait!” Catra called, her voice cracking.

Angella stopped, one hand still on the door. She said nothing.

Catra swallowed. “Please,” she said. “Let me come with you. Let me help.”

For a moment, Angella was silent. Then she turned, and her eyes were piercing, carving Catra up, vivisecting her soul. “Very well,” she said at last. “Guards—release her. She will serve her penance with me.”

She-Ra watched the sun rise. It was something no one on Etheria had seen in a thousand years.

She had emerged from her throne-world on a rocky, barren world that had once been Etheria’s neighbor within its star system. The planet had little atmosphere, and was scorched by devastating solar radiation in the daytime. At one point, Imperial Eternia had established a research outpost on the planet. The site still stood almost undamaged, though the steel dome of the roof was pockmarked with impact sites from hundreds of impacts of micrometeors.

She-Ra was starting to remember the lives she had led before Adora. Mara was clearest, and the memories were returning more slowly the farther back in her past she looked. Mara’s memories

were at this point a source of relief. It was thanks to them that she was able to confirm that the dwarf-planets and moons of the Etherian system were all still in their places.

That meant the Hive had not found the system. They had not noticed the disappearance of one of its planets. If they had they would surely have established a brood here and taken some of the smaller celestial bodies as war-moons. Despondos was safe from any weapon the Eternians had been able to field, but the Hive didn't play by their rules.

The Hive were the only species known to have developed the sword-logic and to have constructed cyst-worlds like Despondos. If anyone could break into She-Ra's sactum, it would be them.

She-Ra's eye caught on a sparkle. Something reflective within the system. An old Eternian satellite? A metallic asteroid? …Or a ship?

She bent her knees and jumped. Physics bent to her will, gravity released its hold on her as she flew upward until 'up' lost meaning. As she approached, the object grew in her vision. It *was* a ship, but not like any Hive vessel she knew of. It was a mobile space-station, a massive supercarrier with hundreds of docking bays for ships of various sizes. It was shaped like a top, with two vast, white sails over the spire at its peak. As she approached, four fighters emerged from one of the hangars and sped in her direction.

She slowed herself with the friction of her will so that when they reached her, she hung stationary in the void. For a moment, all was still. Then the fighters turned and took a formation around her, guiding her in the direction of the hangar. She allowed herself to be led.

A minute later, her golden shoes were making contact with the sterile floor of the hangar. Dozens of figures moved around her—familiar figures. Hordak must have been a member of this species.

She-Ra's brow furrowed as she looked again. They weren't only the same species. Each individual looked *exactly* the same as its fellows. Clones? A species that reproduced asexually? She didn't know.

"Welcome, stranger," said one as it approached her, in the Etherian language.

She nodded at him—it?—in acknowledgement. "I appreciate the greeting," she said. "You seem to have me at a disadvantage—how do you know this language? The only world where it is native should be inaccessible."

The figure's expression did not change—it was perfectly neutral. "Prime's Light touches all worlds," it said. "He sees all, and knows all."

She-Ra considered that, then shrugged. The Hive had gods who could bend physics—why should this race not have one who bent linguistics? "I see. What is this vessel?"

"This is the *Velvet Glove,*" said the figure. "The flagship of Prime's great fleet. He is eager to meet you. Come."

The figure turned and started walking. She followed it into a maze of corridors. "If I might ask," she said, as they passed a pair of identical figures, "are your people all genetically identical, or am I just not versed in the differences between individuals?"

"We are all clones," said her guide, voice as neutral as ever. "Each of us created in the image of Prime to serve him."

"I see."

The rest of the walk was made in silence. They ascended an elevator and emerged to another corridor. Down that corridor was a vast, circular room, brightly lit from above. The throne room—for that was what it was—was dominated by a tall, triangular chair. It faced away from her, into a large array of monitors. Each displayed a different video—she saw an orbital view of a planet

being glassed on one, another was underwater, watching fish and other aquatic creatures moving about. One showed her, from above. She glanced up and her eyes picked out the camera on the spire above her.

Her guide stopped just inside the room. "Hail Horde Prime, Emperor of the Known Universe!" he called out, standing stiffly at attention. "Your visitor has arrived!"

The angular seat rotated to face her. The figure within was white as snow, with glittering green eyes, but markedly different from his clones. For one thing, two additional eyes lay above and below his right eye. His hair was longer, and melded with artificial tendrils in sockets on his shoulders, which looked liable to be external ports for some sort of cranial implant.

The figure was smiling. His teeth were an almost luminous green —or perhaps that was just the lighting, which was an unsettling acid-green and seemed to wash out all surfaces. "Greetings," he said, standing slowly. He was even taller than she was, nine or ten feet at least. He wore a long white robe with what looked like armor plating around his shoulders. He carried no apparent weapon, but his index fingers were encased in—or possible replaced with—metal claws, which might well be sharp.

She nodded deeply, but did not bow. "You must be Horde Prime," she said.

"I am," he said. "But it is *you* I am curious about. I receive an anomalous signal from an empty space in a barren star system, and when I come to investigate I find a woman who seems able to traverse space without protection or propulsion. I confess—you have my attention, and my interest."

"I am She-Ra," said She-Ra. "I have been trapped for a millennium in a cage of my own design, but now I am free."

Horde Prime raised his left eyebrow. His vestigial right eyes darted away from her, then back. "How did you come to be trapped?" he

asked.

"I sealed myself inside my cage with a weapon capable of wiping the universe clean of life," she said evenly. "It was necessary, but I am glad to be able to move freely again."

"This cage—it wouldn't happen to be anchored to this point in space, would it?" Prime asked. "I received a very… unusual signal here, not long ago."

"It is…" She-Ra hesitated. "It's hard to explain, unless you are familiar with the sword-logic. Are you? Familiar, that is."

"I'm afraid not," said Prime, with an air of superiority, like a colonist preparing to hear a native's explanation of his religion.

"Then, in basic terms," said She-Ra, "my cage was a pocket-universe, which houses a planet which once orbited this system's star. I pulled that planet into that pocket-universe, and then could not emerge again. Until now."

Horde Prime studied her for a moment. "Interesting," he said softly. "And, perchance, was one of my little brothers—" he gestured to the clone beside her "—present there?"

She only hesitated for a fraction of a second. "He was," she said. "He called himself Hordak, and tried to conquer the planet with his Horde. I killed him as I left."

Prime's expression twisted—but it was not anger she saw there. It was disgust. "He took a *name*?" he asked. "I knew he was defective, but that was beyond my worst fears. He will be stricken from the record and forgotten." His expression morphed unnaturally quickly back into a smile. "I thank you for ridding me of that nuisance," he said.

She-Ra's expression didn't change, but in her heart, she found she actually felt pity for Hordak. Suddenly, the Horde made a great deal more sense. "If you don't mind, I have a question of my own."

“Of course.” Horde Prime gestured lazily with his hand. “Ask anything you wish.”

“You call yourself ‘Emperor of the Known Universe,’” said She-Ra. “Are you familiar with the Hive?”

Horde Prime frowned thoughtfully. “Not offhand. I can check through the memories of my previous bodies, if you like.”

“No need,” she said. “I have the answer I need. The Hive must not have encountered you.”

“Oh?” Horde Prime blinked languidly. “How are you so certain?”

“Because this vessel is apparently your flagship,” said She-Ra. “The seat of your power. If the Hive had found you, you would be dead.”

The clone beside her tensed. Horde Prime’s expression tightened marginally. Slowly, he sat down. “You sound awfully certain of that.”

“The Hive have been crusading against all life for thousands of millennia,” said She-Ra flatly. “They convert dwarf-planets and satellites into war-moons. They number in the trillions. If this vessel is your flagship, your fleet is simply not strong enough to match them.”

“My fleet,” said Horde Prime coldly, “is as strong as I wish.”

The last word echoed around the chamber. She-Ra’s eyes widened —too late.

Clinging invisible to one of the *Velvet Glove*’s solar sails, a wyrm laughed as it grew fat on desire.

Wish

Chapter Notes

> Catra learns that Beast Island is not a death sentence--it's worse. She-Ra hones her edge on wishes.

Beast Island didn't look much like an island at all, up close. The great tangled mass of ruined technology loomed over the water like an obelisk, a monument to some long-forgotten sin.

"I always thought Beast Island would have, well, *beasts* on it," said Bow aloud, breaking the silence on the deck of the *Dragon's Daughter VI*. "Not old First One's tech."

"Not just any tech," Angella said quietly. "I am a few centuries too young to remember the First Ones, but my mother told me stories of Beast Island when I was small. She told me it was 'where they put the monsters.' The things they couldn't either kill or coexist with. Haywire technology, rampant magic… possibly even stranger things than we can imagine. All were cast away here, where they could not bother the rest of Etheria."

"Encouraging," muttered Catra, glaring balefully up at the dark tech-jungle.

"If you don't want to come…" Glimmer began—for the fourth time.

"I'm coming, Sparkles," Catra snapped. "Just—don't get your hopes up. Entrapta's been here a few days already. Who knows what she's already been through."

"What *you* put her through, you mean!" Glimmer retorted, rage twisting her face.

"Hey, hey!" The newly reinstated Princess Scorpia stepped between them, pincers held out in an attempt at placation. "Let's all take a few deep breaths. We're all here to help Entrapta. Let's focus on that, not on any mistakes we made in the past."

Catra crossed her arm over the ship's wooden railing and stared out at the water, making no reply.

The entire Princess Alliance had come along for this mission, along with Bow. Was Bow a member of the Princess Alliance? Also, did Scorpia count as a member, since she was now technically a Princess, who was allied with the other members of the Alliance? Catra wasn't sure, and didn't much care. They were both here too, and so was she.

As the ship finally hit the shallows and Sea Hawk began turning it aside, Angella flapped her wings once, soaring off the deck and onto the shore. She started as her feet hit the ground, looking down. "Watch your feet!" she called back to the others as Sea Hawk lowered the gangplank. "The ground is sharp!"

Catra frowned, looking at the oddly dark sand on the beach. It wasn't sand at all, she realized suddenly—it was a mulch of fragmented metal, plastic, and other materials.

Scorpia grimaced as her boots hit the false earth. "Oh, that's weird. I do not like that at *all*."

"It's unnatural," agreed Perfuma as she gingerly stepped out onto it and quickly put an arm around one of Scorpia's pincers.

"Bow," Angella called as the rest of them filed out of the ship. "Are you picking up any signals? Anything artificial?"

"There's one active radio signal," Bow reported. "It's coming from somewhere deep inside… that." He gestured vaguely at the mountain of twisted metal. "Somewhere near the center of the island."

"That's gotta be where Entrapta is!" Scorpia said excitedly. "Even if she's not sending it, she'd pick it up and want to see what was making it!"

"Hopefully she saw it before it saw her," muttered Catra, ignoring Glimmer's glare.

"Then that's where we're going," said Angella. "Watch your feet and keep your eyes open. This island has been host to many dangerous things over the centuries, and some of them may still be around."

She-Ra felt the ontological jaws closing on her even as the *Velvet Glove* seemed to waver before her eyes. Horde Prime seemed entirely unaware of the metaphysical transformations happening around him, as did his clones. At another time, the noetic implications of that ignorance would have interested She-Ra—but right now she was otherwise occupied.

"These Hive, whoever they are," Horde Prime growled, "cannot hope to stand against…"

She-Ra stopped listening. She needed a plan, and quickly. And she needed to be *very* careful, because there was an ontological predator on this ship, and if she let her control over her own thoughts slip for even a moment, it would have her. It had happened once already.

She blinked and reexamined that thought. *When* had this happened before? She couldn't remember. Perhaps it was in an earlier life, one that she hadn't yet fully recalled?

Either way, it didn't matter. She knew what an Ahamkara was, and she knew what they could do even to her if she wasn't careful.

"…your caged planet will not be safe."

She blinked and returned to the conversation. The room was bigger than she remembered, now, and clones ringed the outer walls, each one watching a screen as if they had always been there. "I'm sorry," she said, "what did you say? I was distracted."

Horde Prime's eyes—all four of them—widened in fury. "I *said*," he hissed, "that when I bring the full might of my fleet to bear, even your caged planet will not be safe!"

“Ah,” said She-Ra. “Your title was ‘Emperor of the Known Universe.’ How many worlds have you conquered, destroyed, or otherwise beaten? Just out of curiosity.”

“Uncountable thousands,” Prime boasted. “I have long since lost count.”

“Excellent,” said She-Ra, and charged him, blade ready.

He was unprepared, but she felt the Anthem Anatheme being invoked wordlessly as the distance between them rapidly closed. He had wished—but for what? To defend himself, or to defeat her?

She had her answer when her sword pinged off of a forcefield that she was absolutely certain had not been there even an instant before. “You think you can strike me!?” he asked, a mad cackle emerging from his lips. “I am—”

The sword struck again, this time with the weight of a mighty Ascendant Being, empowered by the dark sword-logic, behind it. The shield cracked like an egg, and Horde Prime tore open like the yolk. He went down, still with a crazed smile on his face.

And all the power of a conqueror, a single being who had proven his existence over the corpses of billions of others, flowed into her like water into a vessel. It did not double her power—She-Ra had existed for a very long time, and defeated many terrible and dangerous foes—but it was a significant boost.

She didn’t know whether it would be enough. This Ahamkara had fed off of wishes enough to create the very conqueror she had just struck down. But it would have to be enough—she had no desire for more. Not while the wish-eater was still loose.

Ignoring the screams and wails of the newly orphaned clones, She-Ra grabbed the arm of the one who had originally guided her to the throne room. “Where is the nearest airlock?” she growled.

“You killed him!” the clone screamed in her face. “You have destroyed the source of all light, the only—”

"I am your *monarch!*" she bellowed, feeling the Deep curl around her in satisfaction. "You *will* answer my questions!"

It wasn't a proper Taking. She had seen the monstrosities fielded by the King of Shapes and had no desire to learn that particular ability—assuming she even could, without his Tablets of Ruin. But nonetheless the clone's blubbering quieted. "D-down the corridor and to the left," he said helplessly. "Straight on until the path ends, then to the right and keep going until you reach it."

"Thank you," she said, and ran.

Catra? Adora's voice called suddenly from somewhere in the thicket, tight with pain and confusion.

Catra froze mid-step. "Adora?" she asked, voice cracking, looking around wildly. "Adora, is that you?"

"What?" Glimmer asked, starting and turning back to face her. "What are you—"

"Didn't you hear her?" Catra asked wildly, not even looking at the princess. "Adora! Where are you!"

You need to turn back, Adora's voice said, and Catra realized suddenly that it wasn't coming from somewhere in the jungle. It was reverberating inside her own head, without bothering to knock on her eardrums for admittance. *You're not going to get what you want out of this.*

Catra stood, rooted to the ground, her eyes staring blindly into the glittering technojungle. A tangle of words fought their way up her throat, vowels and consonants wrestling one another away from her lips.

"Catra, what is happening?" Angella's voice was sharp, but seemed somehow a long way off, as though it was echoing through a tunnel. "Are you hearing something?"

I can't give you what you want, Adora's voice said gently. *Turn back. Please.*

Catra swallowed, licked her lips, and managed to speak. "You could have killed me a dozen times," she said. "You never did. You never gave up on me. I'm not giving up on you this time, Adora."

Silence. Then—*Foolish child,* came Shadow Weaver's rasping voice. *Always dogging Adora's footsteps. I always knew it was only a matter of time before you followed her to the rebellion—and now you want to follow her again. I suppose loyalty is admirable, in a pet.*

Catra's eyes slid shut. "You're dead," she said. Her voice shook. "I watched you die." She opened her eyes, glaring hatefully out into the dark. "Who are you? Show yourself!"

"Don't!" A new voice, one she had never head before, called from across the jungle, somewhere hidden in the metal undergrowth. "Whatever it offers you, *don't* accept! Don't even *think* about accepting!"

Catra shook her head, feeling like she was coming out of a deep pool of water. "Who's there?"

"I know that voice," murmured Angella, staring out into the thicket. "It… can't be."

Someone was coming toward their little party. "Don't listen to it!" the man was saying. "I know it must be offering you whatever you want most—*don't* accept! Don't make the wish!"

"I'm not being offered anything," Catra called back roughly. "Who even are you?"

A hand brushed aside a tangle of discarded cords and a man stumbled out into the clearing. His hair and beard were long and thick, shaggy with poor maintenance, and his body was scarcely more than skin and bones, but his dark eyes were clear and fixed on her. "I—what do you mean, it didn't offer you anything?"

"I just heard voices telling me that I *can't* have what I want," Catra growled. "Now, *who*—"

"Micah." Angella's voice was scarcely more than a whisper.

The man blinked and suddenly seemed to notice that there were other people in the clearing. His eyes found Angella and his mouth dropped open. "A-Angie?"

There are some wishes even I cannot grant, said the voice in Catra's head, sounding like Shadow Weaver. This time, however, everyone else started, looking around in surprise. All except Micah, who looked stricken. *Catra's is one of them. Yours, O Exile mine, however… yours has been granted.*

Micah's eyes were fixed on Angie. "It grants wishes," he said in a voice that seemed to grate against his throat like sandpaper. "I wished to survive to see you again."

And now you have, said Shadow Weaver's voice, sweet as poison. *Wish granted, O Morsel mine.*

Micah's eyes slid shut, and he dropped to the ground like a marionette with strings cut. Angella leapt forward and caught him, cradling him against her chest. "He's still breathing," she reported.

I allow him his life for now. Now it sounded like Hordak, of all people. *There is no food fit for humans on this island. I have sustained him these past six years, made it impossible for him to die—until he saw you, his wife and daughter, again.*

Angella stared down at the body in her arms for a moment, then looked out into the dark. "Why let him live, then?" she asked coldly.

I offer you an exchange, Queen of Brightmoon. Take him, alive, and leave this place. Never seek to bring She-Ra back into this plane again.

Catra's fists clenched. "I don't care about some dead guy," she hissed. "I don't care if he's a king. You're not stopping me from trying to get Adora back."

"Wait—" Angella began, but Catra turned on her, hair standing on end in her rage.

"You want to run away, *fine*," she spat. "Run away with your tail between your legs. Take your husband and *abandon* her. Like you did *him*. But you'll have to drag me after you, or I'm *staying*."

"If you stay, there's no guarantee that thing will honor its word," Angella said coldly.

Catra bared her teeth in a wild rictus-grin. "So?" she asked. "Are you willing to fight to abandon Adora? Now you've got what you want, are you going to abandon the people who fought to get you there? You willing to attack me to do it?"

Angella stared down at her, her dark eyes glittering coldly in the dark blue light reflected off of the ruined plating all around them. Then her eyes suddenly flitted to Catra's right. Catra tensed as Glimmer appeared beside her, but Glimmer acted before she could react—

—and put a hand on Catra's shoulder, steady and firm.

"You'll have to fight me, too," she said firmly.

"Glimmer…" Angella began, but trailed off, seemingly lost for words.

"I'm not giving up on Adora," said Glimmer, and her voice shook. Catra saw that there were tears in her eyes. "I'm sorry. I can't. Not after everything she did for us."

In the silence that followed, Bow stepped up to Catra's other side. Then Scorpia came up behind her. Then Perfuma and Frosta.

Mermista stayed apart, looking sick. "I… can't fight for this," she said. "Not either way. Glimmer—are you *sure* about this? It's your *dad*."

"Glimmer took a shuddering breath. "I'm sure."

"Very well," said Angella softly. "I will go and take Micah. I will send a ship back. I only hope that is enough for my husband to be allowed to live." She paused for a moment and then turned away, lifting the unconscious king up in her arms. "Glimmer," she said, without looking at any of them. "I am… so, *so* proud of you." Then, without waiting for a reply, she spread her wings and sailed into the distance.

The voice, which had quieted for their argument, suddenly returned with a growl. *You have no idea what you are asking,* it said, frustrated, still in Shadow Weaver's voice.

"I know *exactly* what I'm asking," growled Catra, glaring deeper into the forest. "I don't want *She-Ra* back. I just want *Adora*."

The two are linked. Entangled. Inextricable. Shadow Weaver's voice almost sounded regretful—a truly strange tone to hear, in that voice. *I should know. I made it so.*

Curiosity

Chapter Summary

She-Ra slays a dragon. Catra finds Entrapta.

"What does that mean?" Glimmer shakily. "Whatever you are, you've been on Beast Island for six years at least, if you were here when my dad arrived. How could you have caused any of this?"

Silence for a moment. Then: *Over a thousand years ago, I was imprisoned here.* The voice was Hordak's again, and the rage in it was familiar. *Forced to live on the tiny, meaningless wishes of the few animals who made their homes on this island, or the occasional sailor I managed to entice and ensnare. But one day everything changed. The very planet tore itself apart, and a being of surpassing power reached out to any who would listen with one fervent desire. I listened. I granted it.*

"What happened a thousand years ago?" Catra asked blankly.

That was when the last She-Ra placed this planet in this cyst-universe, this sword-world called Despondos. Hordak sounded grim, fatalistic. *The planet was shaking itself apart. And the current bearer of the mantle of She-Ra wished to stop it. So, I granted her wish. I gave her the power to create Despondos and seal this world inside. I thought the granting of such a wish would be the rush of power I needed to break free. I miscalculated, and so I have starved here for ten centuries.*

"What do you mean, you *miscalculated*?" Catra asked. She was seething, her hair standing on end. "What did you *do*? Stop speaking in riddles and *answer the question*!"

Silence for a moment. Then—*Your wayward princess wished for knowledge,* came the voice of Shadow Weaver. *Go to the center of the island. I will allow her freedom for a time, and she will explain*

it in terms you may understand better. Your minds are so fickle, and your grasp of language so rudimentary, that I despair of attempting to explain the Sword-Logic and the Anthem Anatheme in terms you will understand.

"What did you do to Entrapta?" shouted Glimmer.

I granted her wish. Shadow Weaver's voice sounded bored. *She wished to know all there was to know of this island. She has been unable to stop reading the logs left by its creators since she arrived. I will put the relevant files before her eyes as you approach.*

The airlock's external door snapped open and She-Ra was pulled out into the vacuum. She turned to face the *Velvet Glove* as momentum pulled her away.

Now that she knew what she was looking for, she could not miss it. The wish-dragon clung to one of the vessel's solar sails, invisible to any spectrum of natural light, but blazing like a beacon in the arcane spectra of the paracausal. Its physical shape was relatively small, only a dozen or so meters in length, but the bulk of its power was vast and ponderous. It had grown fat from strength, feeding on the endless, ever-growing desires of hubristic Horde Prime, always giving him just enough of what he asked for to make him want more. Its many eyes gazed upon her as it slowly unlatched its claws from the vessel.

Greetings, it whispered in her mind, and its voice was familiar, but She-Ra did not bother to place it. *Have you need, perhaps, of my services, O Sword-Goddess mine?*

"I have no need of anything given by your kind," she said, and her voice transmitted across void unhindered. "I *take* what I need."

Not always, it would seem. Its smile was knowing. *I smell my kindred on you. The Anthem Anatheme twines about you like a*

python about its prey. What wish did you make in days past, that have so woven us into you?

She-Ra's denial died on her lips as she remembered. Mara, in the moment of the Heart of Etheria's activation. Her wish to do something, to *fix* things.

Suddenly it all came into awful focus, and she understood.

She-Ra's heart hardened. Her eyes narrowed. "It is no business of yours," she said, to this kindred of the thing that had turned her into the weapon that had killed poor Adora. Even along that winding channel, her rage flowed with joy and sorrow.

It grinned, baring innumerable razor-teeth. *Intend you, then, to kill me? You had best be thorough. For there are a thousandfold thousand souls in the fleet of Horde Prime. Small souls, simple souls, but even their small desires shall serve—O, how they shall serve! And they are bent all now to one desire, one singular Wish. One which you have imparted unto them. 'Woe unto the Horde, for Prime is dead. Would that he should return!' They wish it, O slave-children mine, and shall I not grant them their desire?*

She-Ra felt the priming of the abominable creature's ontological assault and knew that she was out of time. "You shall not," she said, and swung her sword.

The Anthem Anatheme, the subjugation of the objective universe to the subjective will, was a deadly weapon comprised of three components. The wish, formed in language, even unspoken. The invocation, the capture of the wisher in the cage of words. And the activation mechanism, which could vary. Sometimes it was the acceptance of a bargain, the ingestion of larvae, or the breaking of the barriers of space, time, or causality. She-Ra did not know what form it would take here. Nor did she care.

The Sword-Logic had only one component—itself, infinite in recursive invocation. It could slice between seconds, cut between

ideas. It could sever the Anthem from the Anatheme. So it was. Aiat. Aiat.

The wish-dragon's eyes were wide, its teeth forever bared in a victorious rictus-grin. The head bearing them drifted away from the body for a moment before She-Ra took the bulk of the dragon in one hand, and its head in the other, and both she hurled into the nearest sun. For even the bones of a dragon retained their power, even the dust of a dragon retained the echo of the Anthem they sang. But the molecular forge of a blazing star could reduce even dust to atoms, and atoms to quarks, until eventually the causal reasserted itself over the paracausal.

She-Ra panted as she stared after the corpse as it drifted towards Etheria's ancient star, then turned away. She must put aside her mourning for the young woman she had replaced. There was more work to do now.

The Hive remained. Xivu Arath would be waiting, and She-Ra, now far mightier than she had ever been as merely Mara wielding her mantle, would meet her in battle. She had stood fast against the onslaught of War Itself once before. She had not broken then.

This time, it would break upon her.

Entrapta's hair hung loosely around her shoulders. Dark rings were around her eyes, which were slowly trailing along an endless column of text slowly scrolling down a glowing blue screen. Her arms were emaciated where they sat on the armrests of the straight-backed chair in which she sat.

Scorpia made a wounded noise as she followed Catra inside and saw Entrapta. "Oh, no," she murmured. "Entrapta, you gotta take better care of yourself."

Entrapta didn't react at all. She didn't seem to hear them. There was no curious spark in her eye, no manic grin lighting up her

face. She just stared at the screen of endlessly scrolling information, trapped in limbo.

"There's got to be a way to snap her out of it," Glimmer muttered, staring down at the trapped princess with no expression at all on her face. "There's got to be a way—"

There is not. The voice spoke, and this time it sounded like Entrapta herself. *Even I cannot undo what I have now done. But I can set her free for a while, in answer to your desire to understand.*

Entrapta blinked. Slowly, like a tree coming loose from the earth in a hurricane, she tore her eyes from the screen. Her head lolled on her shoulder as she turned to gaze at them. "You came," she said. There was no energy in her voice, no excitement, no life at all. She sounded hollow, as though all the crackling spark that had made her Entrapta had been scooped out of her with a spoon.

"Yeah, we came," Scorpia said. "We're gonna get you out of here —"

"You can't," Entrapta said dully. "The Anthem Anatheme violates time-symmetry. It isn't reversible. The wish was made, and its results are now causal fact. Now no one, not even the original wish-granter, can unmake it."

"I'm so sorry." The words emerged from Catra almost before she realized she was speaking. All she could see was the almost translucent paleness of Entrapta's skin, the way her cheekbones jutted out of her sallow face. "This is all my fault. I'm so, so sorry, Entrapta."

Entrapta's eyes rotated to face her slowly, like marbles being turned between fingers. For a moment she was silent. Then her cracked lips opened again and formed words. "You're here so that I can explain something," she said. "What is it?"

"That *thing* claims it's the reason all of this happened," said Bow. His face was set in hard, determined lines. "What does it mean?"

“It’s called an Ahamkara. A wish-dragon.” Entrapta’s voice was monotone, robotic. “Their species developed an unusual diet on their homeworld. They feed on wishes. Specifically, they draw sustenance from the energy released when they close the space between objective reality-as-it-is, and subjective reality-as-is-desired. Are you with me so far?”

“Nope, pretty lost,” said Scorpia sheepishly.

Entrapta blinked once. “The voice is a wish-dragon,” she said. “Wish-dragons eat wishes. When they grant a wish, it’s like a meal to them. The bigger and more impressive the wish, the bigger and tastier the meal.”

“Oh, okay. I think I get it.” Scorpia looked thoughtful.

“So it granted King Micah’s wish, and yours, but not in the ways you wanted.” Mermista, for once, did not sound bored at all. She sounded almost scared. “And it… *ate* the wishes? I guess?”

“Something like that,” Entrapta confirmed. “This ability to close the gap between desire and reality, and to draw power from doing so, is called the Anthem Anatheme. It’s magical—or paracausal, as the First Ones called it—and doesn’t obey all the rules of normal, physical reality. Just like magic can keep ice from melting no matter how hot it gets. It violates normal, physical laws. Still with me?”

“Still with you,” Catra confirmed softly. Her eyes prickled but remained almost traitorously dry.

“Okay.” Entrapta’s eyelids slowly closed and opened in a glacial blink. “New topic. The First Ones sent the She-Ra before Adora, a woman named Mara, to Etheria to study its magic as part of a secret plan. They called that plan the ‘Heart of Etheria’ project. They were fighting a war against an alien race called the Hive, and the Heart of Etheria was supposed to be a superweapon that would wipe the Hive out. Do you understand?”

“I think so,” said Catra.

"Good. Mara was supposed to activate the Heart of Etheria, but she learned about the collateral damage it would cause—something her superiors had kept from her. The death toll would have been in the tens of trillions of innocent lives."

Catra's eyes grew wide. *Trillions?*

"Wait," Frosta said. "What's that number? I literally don't think I've ever heard it before."

"Nothing a normal Etherian interacts with can be counted in the trillions," Entrapta answered in that same horrible monotone. "It is one thousand billions. A billion is a thousand millions. A million is a thousand thousands. So, one trillion is one followed by twelve zeroes. A single trillion people is approximately ten thousand times more people than have ever been born on Etheria. The death toll estimated for the Heart of Etheria, not including the entire Hive, was more than twenty of those."

Catra stared as Entrapta laid the numbers out. Her voice never changed in its inflection. She never gave any indication that she cared what any of these horrific facts she was saying meant. She was just an automaton to ingest and explain information, nothing more.

"O-oh," Perfuma said faintly. "That's a lotta people."

"Yes," agreed Entrapta. "Every intelligent lifeform not directly allied to the First Ones in the entire universe would have died. The First Ones had only explored approximately one millionth of one percent of the observable universe. If life was equally common throughout the universe, then there would be tens of trillions, perhaps hundreds of trillions, of people who had never even heard of a First One, who would have all died when the Heart of Etheria was activated."

"So Mara refused," Glimmer said shakily. "Refused to activate it."

"It was not so simple," Entrapta said evenly. "Mara could choose not to direct the Heart of Etheria, but the result of that would be

that the planet would shake itself apart with uncontained magic. So she wished for a solution that would allow both Etheria and the wider universe to survive."

"And the wish-dragon granted that wish by letting her put the planet in this… sword-world?" Bow asked.

"Despondos. And not quite," Entrapta said. "This requires one additional topic. The Hive have a religion they call the Sword-Logic. This religion, like the Anthem Anatheme, is paracausal—magical. A person who devotes themselves to the Sword-Logic can gain magical power by killing their enemies. The more powerful the enemy, the more power they gain. Understand?"

Bow nodded, so Entrapta continued. "She-Ra has existed for tens of thousands of years at least," she said. "Possibly millions, or even more. She existed only as a mantle of power—a semi-sentient energy source which transferred from one bearer to the next. Until Mara made that wish.

"The wish-dragon granted the wish by transforming She-Ra. She-Ra had, over her thousands of incarnations, killed a vast number of people. Most of those people were powerful: crime lords, evil wizards, mad kings, and so on. Because She-Ra was not a single entity, but rather a lineage, that power was not accumulated through the Sword-Logic. The Ahamkara changed She-Ra into an identity, a mind unto itself, capable of accumulating its own power. This gave her access to the Sword-Logic, and through it, a particular power of Sword-Logic practitioners: a Throne World.

"A Throne World is a pocket-universe created by a powerful being in the Sword-Logic. Within it, their will is absolute. Despondos is She-Ra's throne world, created when she became a person with her own accumulated power. She-Ra sealed Etheria inside, and then Mara crashed, and she died."

"Until she chose Adora," Catra said hoarsely.

“Yes.” Entrapta gave another ponderous blink. “Adora was at first merely mantling She-Ra. The unfinished portal tore open She-Ra’s Throne World, which is a part of her identity. The action woke her, and she immediately overtook Adora, subsuming her and making her a part of the gestalt identity of She-Ra.”

Secrets

Chapter Summary

> Catra makes a plan. She-Ra and Xivu Arath face each other acrossa vast, but rapidly closing, distance.

Catra felt like she might throw up. She pressed on instead. "Okay. So why did she leave? And why won't the dragon help us bring her back? It said it miscalculated."

"Yes," Entrapta said. "The Dragon gained immense power by granting Mara's wish. Creating an ascendent being, a god, in the Sword-Logic was an incredible change. However, before it could do anything with that power, Etheria, and its prison on this island, were swallowed up by Despondos, trapping it here. For all its power, it had no way to break out of its prison without someone to make a wish that would grant it freedom. And without any First Ones ships, scientists, or explorers, no one was coming to Beast Island. It slowly starved to death, and when it died, its death was one more powerful being She-Ra had killed. In this way, all of the power generated through She-Ra's creation flowed eventually back into She-Ra herself, and the dragon was left as nothing more than dusty bones."

"What?" Glimmer frowned at Entrapta. "But the dragon isn't dead. It granted your wish, and my dad's."

"Just as magical fire can burn without fuel, so can an Ahamkara's bones grant wishes even when there is no life animating them." Entrapta gave another of her terrible slow blinks. "Ahamkara die, but they do not pass away like humans do. They just fade into the background. But they can always be brought back if someone feeds them with enough wishes on their bones."

Catra bared her teeth. "Okay. That's great. Fantastic. Now why did it say it can't bring Adora back? Is it just scared of her?"

"No," Entrapta said. "The Anthem Anatheme has one fundamental limit. A wish, once made, cannot be unmade by another invocation of the Anthem Anatheme. Because Mara's wish created the She-Ra identity, the Anthem Anatheme cannot unmake her. This is why, once we're done here, I'll have to go back to my reading. My wish to learn put me in this position, and no amount of wishing can undo it."

"Even if the Anthem Anatheme can't undo what happened," Glimmer said, "maybe something else can?"

Entrapta stared at Glimmer in silence for a long moment. "I don't know," she said, and for the first time there was a crack in her monotone, a faint shudder in her voice. "Nothing natural—no tech or science—could do it. But perhaps another paracausal power could. Maybe an immensely powerful spell…"

"The Sword-Logic," Catra said slowly. "The Sword-Logic can undo it, I'll bet."

Entrapta stared at her. "It is possible," she said.

"And She-Ra already has power from having killed this Ahamkara," said Catra quietly.

"Wait, wait," Glimmer said, staring at her. "You're suggesting we get She-Ra to undo the wish… that *created* She-Ra? How would we even convince her to do that?"

Catra clenched her fists. "If she's just She-Ra now, we can't," she said. "But if Adora's still in there, somewhere? Then we'd have a chance." She looked Glimmer in the eye. "Are you willing to bet everything on Adora?"

"Are you?" Glimmer challenged.

"I already am," Catra said flatly, then turned back to Entrapta. "How can we summon She-Ra back?"

"You will need her sword," said Entrapta.

“She took the sword with her when she left,” Catra said.

“She-Ra is empowered by the Sword-Logic. Her ‘sword’ is more than just the metal she carries around,” Entrapta said. “One of her most powerful swords is at the top of this tower.”

“The wish-dragon’s bones,” Glimmer whispered.

“Use them to open a portal,” Entrapta said. “Even if the portal doesn’t work perfectly, She-Ra will return to Despondos to fix whatever it breaks. And it shouldn’t fail as catastrophically as last time, now that the planet is in balance.”

Catra nodded slowly. “Okay,” she said. “We have a plan.”

Xivu Arath’s fleet was vast enough to block out the skies of any world, even one so large as the ancient Fundament. Small tomb-ships sailed alongside mythocrafts the size of buildings, and capital-ships larger than cities, dotted here and there with the vast expanses of war-moons propelled with engines fueled by the ceaseless death of those blessed to live in constant war within the catacomb-hives throughout the crust of each.

Xivu Arath’s flagship was not one of these war-moons. Nor was it one of the capital-ships, or the mythocraft frigates. She stood upon the bridge of a small, silvery craft with a single solar fin, whose hul had been overgrown and infested with chitin and veins of soulfire. The silver needle-ship, whose creators were long forgotten, sailed at the fore of the last and only armada the universe would ever know.

Her worm feasted ravenously on the metaphysical tribute of trillions of Hive engaged warfare—against one another, against any who opposed them, or in the absence of anything else, against themselves. Even so, it gnawed at her belly, ever pushing, ever driving her to seek more.

As the vessels propelled themselves across space without passing through it, sliding across the universe like water over glass, her

three baleful eyes remained fixed on a point growing ever closer. This hunt, this test of her existence, took precedence over all of the other, lesser wars she oversaw. Her sister's heresy would be dealt with another day. The conquest of the remote holdings of the empire whose heart she had just eaten would be handled by her lieutenants. Xivu Arath was concerned now with the only thing in the world that mattered—existence, and her unending struggle to exist.

There was one living thing which had stood against her and lived. Xivu Arath had only survived by feeding on the tribute her armada collected for her. She must now prove that she could overcome this thing or render her existence meaningless.

You can't do this! Adora's voice screeched in Catra's ear, panicked and angry. *You have no idea what you'll unleash!*

"Would you shut up already?" growled Catra, tapping her foot impatiently on the stone floor. "Arrows, how long until this gate is down?"

"Hey, if you think you can do it faster, be my guest," muttered Bow, fiddling with the control panel.

The party had been stopped by a force-field. The room beyond was large and cylindrical, and suspended within it seemed to be some sort of floating cell. Catra had immediately called for the barrier to be taken down, and Bow had found a control panel hidden behind a panel in the wall and gotten to work.

I can make you forget her! the dragon coaxed, still in Adora's voice. *Take all the pain away.*

"You really think I want that?" Catra asked dryly. "For being in my head, you really don't see much."

I can transpose your memories of her onto someone else. Someone who will return your feelings. I can give you everything

you've ever wanted if you only let go of the fantasy that you can have it all with She-Ra.

"You really don't get it," Catra said, and found she was grinning. She'd always enjoyed listening to her foes plead. "Every force on the planet has tried to make me let go of Adora by now. Not one of them has managed it. Nor will you."

You think she will thank you? Adora's voice was a poisonous, cold hiss. *After everything you've done to her? You've* killed *her, you know. Left her to be slaughtered by She-Ra, eaten alive by the ravenous gestalt, mind and all.*

"I don't care if she thanks me," Catra said, and was honestly surprised to find that her words felt true. "She can hate me if she wants. So long as it's *her*."

It won't be! Adora wailed. *Why can't you see that?*

"Then I'll die trying," said Catra simply.

"Got it," Bow said, stepping back as the force field went down.

"Nice," Catra said, stepping past him into the room. The princesses filed in behind her.

Please, Catra! Adora's voice cried, her voice breaking on Catra's name, and Catra's bruised heart cracked alongside.

"Not exactly endearing yourself to me," growled Catra, looking up at the suspended cage. It was held up by a cord from above, which she followed with her eyes. It came back down along the wall. She crossed the room and slashed through it with her claws. The cage fell to the ground with a clang and a rattle, and Adora's voice screamed in pain in her ears.

Inside the cage was a tangled pile of old bones, an unnatural, polished white. The cage itself was a metal net which crackled with electricity, sparking in arcs between the wires, but as she watched the flickering blue light gradually died away.

“Think you can get this one open, too?” she asked Bow.

Bow nodded, crossing over and examining the visible lock on the hinged gate to the cage. “Huh,” he said, surprised. “Looks totally mechanical.”

“What’s that mean?” asked Scorpia.

“It means, we can just…” Bow pilled out a pair of thin metal objects and carefully inserted them into the keyhole, jiggling them about slightly as he felt out the hammers.

“Arrows,” Catra said flatly. “Let me.”

Bow blinked at her and stepped back. Catra took his place, slipped a claw into the lock, and with a practiced twist the gate swung open. “Nice,” said Scorpia appreciatively. “Where’d you learn to do that?”

“Lotta locked doors in the Fright Zone,” said Catra, reaching down and starting to scoop up bones. “I wasn’t exactly a model cadet. Now help me with this stuff, would you? We’ve gotta get back to the mainland, and Entrapta’s old equipment.”

“We’re not leaving Entrapta here, are we?” Glimmer asked.

“Didn’t you hear her?” Catra retorted. “We don’t have a choice. We *can’t* pull her away from that screen. I don’t want to know what happens if we try. If this works, Adora will be able to break the wish the same way she’ll break the last She-Ra’s.”

“What if doing that prevents her from being able to, you know, Do the Sword-Logic thing, or whatever?” asked Mermista.

Catra grimaced. She *had* thought of that. “We’ll cross that bridge when we come to it,” she said. “Look, you wanna try and pull Entrapta away from that screen, be my guest. I take no responsibility for what happens.”

I can let you take Entrapta back with you to the mainland, said Shadow Weaver's voice suddenly. *If that is what you wish, O Princesses mine.*

"Nope," said Catra flatly. "Nope, we're not listening to that. No wishes. We're leaving. Now."

"Fine," snapped Glimmer, wincing and shaking her head as if to clear a headache. "But we're coming back for Entrapta later, whatever happens."

"I'll be right there with you, Sparkles," Catra said. "Promise."

She-Ra stood upon the surface of a rogue asteroid, sailing in the blackness between solar systems. The unfiltered starlight tickled her skin and brushed through her hair, high-energy photons striving to invade her cells and being rejected by the superlative paracausal over their mere causal nature. The soundless scream of stars, the blindingly bright blackness of the void, all folded around her like paper around a knife-blade.

She watched as the vast fleet approached, tens of thousands of ships, a sword thrusting directly at her heart. Xivu Arath remembered their battle as well as she did, and she had brought the High War with her to their reunion.

So be it. Xivu Arath had a sword made of hundreds of millions of Hive. She-Ra had a sword made of hundreds of thousands of dead kings, wizards, slavers, murderers. It was time to see which was sharper.

She bent her knees, and the asteroid crumbled to dust as she leapt. Light doppler-bent around her as she lanced forward, the tip of a spear that was as long as ten thousand millennia.

Across light-years of space, her eyes met Xivu Arath's. They both grinned, anticipatory, hungry.

If I am defeated, I know that I will fall to something mighty. Something that craves might, something that loves what I love.

"If I fail," mouthed Xivu Arath across vast space, *"Let me be wormfood."*

War

Chapter Summary

> She-Ra's blade meets Xivu Arath's. Catra opens a new portal. Light Hope strikes.

"Okay," Bow said, letting out a tight exhale. "I… *think* I did it."

"No room for mistakes here, Arrows," said Catra, her eyes roving over the tangled cords and struts. Bow had done his best to reconstruct Entrapta's portal tech, with help from Scorpia and her pet robot.

"Not like I have an answer key here," Bow grumbled. "It's totally possible that we'll do the almost-destroy-the-world thing all over again. I still don't know what caused that one."

Catra shrugged. "She-Ra will probably notice and stop it if we do," she said. "The entire world is, like, part of her, right? Something like that. We just want to get her attention."

"Well, it'll probably do that, at least!" Bow throws up his hands and steps away from the makeshift portal. "All we need now is our, uh 'sword'."

"I'll grab it!" Glimmer chimed in from her seat on a bulkhead. She stood and with a flash blinked out of existence.

Bow looked at the place where she had vanished, an odd look on his face. "I hope she's doing okay," he said.

"She's *your* friend," Catra pointed out. "You're asking me?"

Bow sighed. "She's not talking to me," he said. "Don't really think she's talking to anybody."

King Micah was still comatose, even more than a week after his return from Beast Island. He had not died, but he seemed liable

to if he was taken off of Castaspella's magical life support. Glimmer's mother scarcely left his side, but Glimmer herself seemed unwilling to visit, spending most of her time trailing Bow and Catra as they tried to piece together Entrapta's portal tech.

Glimmer popped back into existence before Catra could reply. In her arms was a cloth-wrapped bundle, carefully covered so that someone who didn't know what they were looking for might think it to be several poles or weapons.

You're making a mistake—

"Shut up," Catra told Adora's intrusive voice. "Sparkles, pop it in."

Glimmer nodded, face set, and flashed over to the portal engine. She unrolled the cloth in one motion and dumped the polished bones into the center of the machine.

You can't—

"Testing power," Bow said loudly, drowning out the voice. He tugged down on a heavy lever, and the voice was cut off by a strangled cry. Pale light arced from the ring of metal, clinging to the bones like lightning running along a copper cage. Slowly the bones began to rise, slowly orbiting within the portal casing in a glacial whirlwind of ossified white.

"Looks good!" Catra called over to him.

He nodded. Sweat was beading on his brow. "Gotta admit, I'm worried about this," he said, glancing over at Catra. "What if something goes wrong? What if we make things worse?"

Catra just looked at him. "Arrows," she said patiently. "You're barking up the wrong tree. From my perspective, they *can't*."

"We have to try," Glimmer said, her voice hard. "Adora wouldn't give up on us. This is our only plan, so we have to follow through. The alternative is doing nothing. I *won't* do nothing."

Bow took a deep breath. “Right. You’re right.” He swallowed. “Okay. Opening a portal out of Despondos in three… two… one.”

He pulled down on another lever and the room went white.

-x-x-x-

She-Ra dodged out of the way of a blast of condensed Soulfire the size of a large asteroid. A single swing of her sword, ontologically lengthened beyond its own steel, and the three-mile-radius ritual circle which had launched it from the surface of a war-moon shattered as if hit with a nuclear bomb, sending regolith, veins of Soulfire, clarified Void and fragments of chitin all scattering into the infinite black.

She spun and caught another blast of power on her sword, deflecting it into a nearby carrier. Xivu Arath had not emerged from her ship yet. She would. This battle, carving through thousands of lesser Hive—it was the equivalent of pleasantries in the ‘conversation’ of the Sword-Logic. Xivu Arath offered She-Ra a trickle of tribute, a small platter to whet her appetite before they engaged in the true test.

She-Ra almost wished she didn’t enjoy it so much. With the revelation of her nature, of what had happened to poor Adora, it felt like a betrayal. But she could be nothing other than what she was. Whatever the reason, she was now a creature of the Sword-Logic. This dialogue, her sword against the war-god’s—this was what she lived for. This, this *struggle*, it was why she existed, how she existed, and what her existence meant.

At last, after anywhere from hours to days of constant barrage from the armada, the silvery flagship rotated. Its spire opened like the petals of a flower in the morning, and Xivu Arath emerged. Her eyes were fires, her smile was poison, her chitin was titanium. Her sword was a sword, pure in its simplicity.

Their eyes met across the vast space. Then, as one, both charged.

Blade met blade, deflected, and met again. Swordplay was an art both had perfected over uncountable generations. Their blades flashed in the light of uncountable stars, glaring green in the reflected soulfire. Honed edge impacted honed edge with the force of blooming galaxies.

She-Ra lost herself in the rhythm, the dance. Time passed—minutes, hours, days. She and Xivu Arath, the war hero and war incarnate, locked in endless conversant battle. It felt like this moment would stretch onward until the last suns burned out, until black holes swallowed up the final thoughts of a dying universe.

Alas—nothing lasts forever.

She-Ra felt it like a sudden found, deep within her belly. None of Xivu Arath's weapons—a dagger piercing outward, from within. A knife wedged into the flesh of Despondos. She flinched, and the momentary distraction cost her dearly.

She was a moment too late to fully deflect Xivu Arath's next blow. The great blade of war skidded along the shining length of her sword, the impact thudding against her, sending her sailing backwards into the black. Xivu Arath roared in triumph and lunged for the kill. She-Ra barely got her sword up in time, and again was blasted backwards.

She tumbled directly into an opening gap within space. Her feet met solid ground. She staggered at the sudden intrusion of gravity upon her body.

Catra, Bow, and Glimmer all lowered the hands that had been shielding their eyes. They blinked at her, then looked back at the open portal.

At the figure that was following her through.

"*No.*" She-Ra's voice was iron, her will bolstered by desperation. She lunged.

Xivu-Arath met her blade with her own. The Hive god's bulk was half-in, half-out of Despondos, her soulfire eyes lighting the small room with unholy brilliance. She bared her sharp teeth in a wild grin. She knew where this was—She-Ra's sword-world was exposed. A death now would be a final one.

She-Ra bared her teeth and braced, but Xivu Arath smelled blood in the water, and in her hunger was implacable. She took one step, forcing She-Ra back, until she was almost fully within the throne world.

A sudden movement. Xivu Arath recoiled with a scream, one flaming eye going dark and bleeding venom-green ichor. Catra screamed too, as the war-god's soulfire eye burned at her hand and claws. She-Ra took the opportunity. A single upward stroke of her sword tore through Xivu Arath's armor, forcing her back out of the portal. Then she swung again, a wider arc, cleaving through the metal housing for the portal. The doorway into real-space flickered out of existence with a dying scream. A pile of bones fell to the ground and collapsed into dust.

For a moment there was silence, save for She-Ra's heavy breathing and Catra's pained hiss. Then She-Ra turned her furious blue eyes on Adora's former friends. "What were you thinking?" she growled dangerously. "You could have unleashed—"

She stopped. Her sword was warming in her hand. She looked down and saw that it was glowing, flickering in prismatic rainbows of light. Etherian magic. She looked up and saw that the same halo was surrounding Glimmer, who looked as surprised as she was.

"What's…?" the Princess began, and then doubled over in sudden pain.

She-Ra felt it, too. A web of magic suddenly roaring to life, spreading across the planet like a spark through a circuit. She felt her sword humming in her hand, trying to reach binding tendrils into her brain, trying to *force* her to fulfill its purpose.

Suddenly it all came into focus. Her memories as Mara—the Heart of Etheria—the Sword of Protection. The Eternian artifact empowered her, yes, but it also chained her to the will of that defunct empire. The Runestone network must have been balanced while she dealt with Horde Prime and sought out Xivu Arath—and now, the overseer AI the Eternians had left behind was sending the activation sequence to their superweapon's trigger.

Her.

Her eyes flared with brilliant fury. "You think you can control me?" she hissed down at the weapon in her hand, stubbornly tugging at her arm, trying to pull her fingers upward. "*Me?*" She laughed mirthlessly, the cold sound filling the metal chamber. "Never." She swung the blade, embedding it in the wall, and pulled against it, tugging the flat of the sword against steel like a lever.

The Sword of Protection snapped in two, and that was the last thing She-Ra remembered for a while.

-x-x-x-

"Adora!" Catra screamed as she fell. She lunged and caught Adora—for it was Adora, the She-Ra transformation dissipating as she fell—before her head hit the ground. She moved to cradle her in her arms, but her right hand burned when it touched Adora's back, so with a wince she made do with simply holding up Adora's head on her lap.

Behind her, Glimmer fell to her knees with a gasp, the rainbow halo vanishing from around her. Bow rushed to her side.

Catra looked over at them. They stared back, eyes wide. "Are we done?" she asked. "Is it over?"

Bow glanced past her. "I… think the bones are toast," he said, pointing at a scattered pile of pale dust. "So… maybe?"

"Let's go," growled Glimmer, forcing herself to her feet, her teeth clenched in pain. "We need to check on my dad. And get her," she

gestured at Adora, “to bed.”

Catra nodded. “Little help, Arrows?” she asked, gesturing with her right hand, which was stained with an angry greenish wound.

Bow nodded and came over. He took Adora gently and hoisted her up in his arms, cradling her neck carefully to keep it from flopping back. Glimmer put one hand on his shoulder and held another out to Catra. Without hesitation, Catra took it, and the world vanished.

When her sight returned, they were in a private room in the castle’s medical wing. Angella was seated beside a bed, leaning over the blanketed figure within. She started up and looked their way at the tinkling of Glimmer’s teleport. “Glimmer,” she said, her voice breathless, and then noticed the figure in Bow’s arms. “Oh my,” she said. “Is she—”

“She’s alive,” Catra said. “Unconscious.”

“That’s good,” Angella said, audibly relieved, she looked back down at the bed, then over at Glimmer. “Glimmer…”

“Is he…” Glimmer audibly swallowed. “The wish-dragon—Adora killed it. Its bones are dust. Did… anything change.”

Angella’s face said everything before she opened her mouth. “Nothing. He’s still comatose.”

“She-Ra didn’t change back into Adora until she broke the Sword,” Catra pointed out. “I don’t think the wishes will get undone automatically. It doesn’t mean Adora won’t be able to do it once she’s up.”

Glimmer looked up at her through red eyes. Slowly she nodded, then wiped them with the back of her hand. “You’re right,” she said. “We have to keep hoping.” She looked back at the bed longingly. “For my dad, and for Entrapta.”

Catra swallowed down the guilt. There would be time for that later. "We should get Adora to bed," she said instead.

"Take a spare bed," Angella said, gesturing around at the mostly-empty hospital.

"No," said Glimmer tightly. "She's not injured, just drained. She can recover in her room."

Angella looked at her daughter sadly, but all she said was, "Very well, Glimmer."

A flash of light, and they were all in Adora's large, curtained room. Catra had glanced in here exactly once, after she'd been released from prison, just to see where Adora had been between the times when Catra was actively hurting her. It was even bigger than it had seemed from the doorway, with a high, curved ceiling.

She and Bow carried Adora to the bed, and Glimmer pulled the covers up over her. Then she looked at Catra. "You want me to get you a couch or something?"

Catra tore her gaze from Adora to blink down at the Princess. "What?"

"So you can stay here," Glimmer said. Her face was a blank mask. Catra knew that expression. She'd worn it after many late nights at Shadow Weaver's mercy.

"I… No thanks," Catra said. "I won't need it."

Glimmer nodded sharply. "Just don't joslet her too much, all right?"

"I won't. Sparkles—"

"If that's all—"

"Glimmer."

Glimmer blinked in surprise at her real name coming out of Catra's mouth. "What?" she asked sharply.

"Don't…" Catra swallowed. "Don't avoid them."

"I'm not avoiding—"

"You *really* think I don't know what it looks like?"

Glimmer didn't answer.

"Don't push people away just because you're scared of losing them," said Catra, thinking of Adora's tearful eyes as Shadow Weaver's door closed between them. "The regret will only make it worse."

Glimmer stared at her with glistening eyes. Then, with a sound like bells, she vanished.

Bow smiled sadly at her. "Let me know if either of you need anything," he said, nodding at Adora.

"I will," she said. "Thanks, Arrows."

Sword

Chapter Summary

Adora wakes up.

Her eyes opened slowly. The world slowly drifted into focus.

She lay in a plush bed, nestled among cushions. Lavender curtains were draped around her, shrouding her mattress from the outside.

She recognized this room.

A soft sound beside her made her turn her head. Catra lay curled by her knee, dressed in silken red pajamas that could not have come from anywhere but Brightmoon. She dozed almost silently, curled into a small disc, her head resting on a pillow cupped in one hand. The other was wrapped in bandages and held close to her chest.

She stared for a moment at her onetime friend, wondering at the feelings rising up in her. Warmth, unfamiliar but not unwelcome, was seeping into her limbs from deep within her chest.

Then she tried to move. The sudden, sharp pain in her belly as she tried to sit up was a shock of cold water to her system, and she let out an involuntary groan.

Beside her, Catra's eyes snapped open, the name "Adora?" on her lips even as she emerged from sleep. She blinked up at her, then sat up, carefully cradling her injured hands. "You're awake. How are you feeling?"

"I…" she hesitated, diagnosing herself. "…sore."

Catra's eyes were dark with worry. "Anywhere in particular? We didn't find any injuries on you, but…"

“No injuries. Just fatigue.” Slowly, with both hands, she managed to push herself into a sitting position. “Where… this is Brightmoon.”

“Yeah,” Catra said. “After you reverted, we brought you to your room to recover.”

“Reverted?”

Catra blinked. “Uh. Yeah?” Then she flushed. “Sorry. Somehow I assumed you’d notice you weren’t eight feet tall anymore.”

Her hands were soft. Small. She raised them up to her eyes, turning them over. Then she noticed the clothes she was wearing —not She-Ra’s white dress, but her own adapted Horde sleepwear.

Wait.

“What happened?” she croaked.

“Well, the portal shut down and you snapped the sword, then shrank back down,” said Catra. Her wide eyes darted from her head, to her legs, to her torso, and back again in something like astonishment, as if she could scarcely believe she was here. “Sorry. A lot’s happened. You’ve been… away, for a while.”

She blinked at Catra for a moment. She licked her lips. “I… suppose I have.”

Catra studied her, and now there was another darkness in her eyes—fear, and a fragility that tore her apart to see. “I… I hoped, when you, uh, transformed back…” Catra falls silent for a moment. “I have to ask. Are you… are you still…?”

“She-Ra.” The name was oddly bitter on her tongue. Something stirred within her, recognizing the name, something powerful, and deep, and Dark; but it just shifted and settled back deep inside.

Catra was staring at her. She looked like a strong breeze could break her like a blade of grass.

Adora swallowed. "I don't think so," she said. "The line's a little blurry. I remember everything. I remember it being *me* doing everything. I remember being Mara, and all of the previous She-Ras. But I don't… *feel* the way I did. It'll take me some time to sort it all out, I think."

Catra's eyes filled with tears. "You have time," she said, her voice breaking. "You have as long as you need, Adora. *Adora.*" She reached out with her good hand, hesitant, as if worried she might scare Adora away. Adora took it in hers.

"Catra," she murmured. She blinked twice, three times, rapidly. "Catra. What—what are you doing here? What happened after I—after She-Ra left?"

Catra took a breath and started to laugh. It was an almost broken sound. "It's… a long story."

On an impulse, Adora reached out with her other hand and brushed Catra's hair out of her face. Catra practically melted into her touch. "I can listen to it later," she said. "I just have one question that can't wait." She swallowed. "Are you… here, now? In Brightmoon? With me?"

Catra's heterochromatic eyes seemed to fill her vision. "For as long as you'll have me."

With a sigh that was like letting go, Adora fell into Catra's arms.

-x-x-x-

Adora's legs shook under her when she tried to stand, so it was with Catra's help that she carefully tottered her way out of her room. She leaned heavily on her former bunkmate, feeling unsteady and sick with every step. Catra held her up without a noise of complaint, her tail twining around one of Adora's legs as

if she wanted as much contact as possible, to remind herself that Adora was still here.

They made it something like fifty feet down the hall towards the mess hall—or, wait, they called it a dining room in Brightmoon—when Adora heard a cry behind them. "She's up!"

A flash of light before her eyes and Glimmer and Bow stood before them, beaming. There were dark circles under Glimmer's eyes, but her smile positively sparkled. "Adora!" she exclaimed, before throwing her arms around her.

Adora left out a gasp as the sudden push knocked her off her tenuous balance, but Catra's arm darted out and wrapped around her waist, pulling her in tight. "Careful there, Sparkles," she said, and Adora was astonished at her tone—for there was no caustic bite, no angry lash to it. It sounded positively warm, if worried. "She's not at 100% yet."

"Oh, right! Sorry, Adora!" Glimmer stepped back, still smiling widely—

—bared, sharp teeth; soulfire-green eyes gazing down flickering with madness and murder—

Adora took a shuddering breath and closed her eyes, banishing the vision. Bow's voice broke the surface of her perception like a diver into a lake, his voice seeming to come from far off before returning to normal. "—you all right? Adora? What's wrong?"

Adora's eyes opened again. All three of them were gazing worriedly at her. "I'm fine," she said. "Just—I'm fine."

Glimmer looked askance. "No, you're not," she said gently. "Adora, no one's *expecting* you to—"

"What was it?" Catra's brow was furrowed, her expressive face twisting into a sad, worried frown. "What did you… see?"

Adora swallowed, clinging to Catra like a lifeline. “Her face,” she murmured, burying her head in Catra’s shoulder. “Her eyes.”

“She-Ra’s?”

“*Xivu Arath’s*.” Her head snapped up and she stared at Catra, memory suddenly flooding back. “You *scratched out her eye!?*”

A muscle jumped in Catra’s mouth. “That thing was a *she*?” she asked blankly.

“That was the *god of war*. And you scratched out her eye!” Adora’s eyes darted to Catra’s bandaged hand. “Are you okay?”

Catra followed her gaze. “Oh, this? Yeah. It’s just a burn, it’s healing.” She looked at Adora, still holding her up with one arm, and gently rested her other hand on her cheek. “It’s okay,” she said. “She can’t get to you here. You have time to recover. To rest.”

Adora swallowed. “You’re right,” she said.

At that moment, her stomach growled. Glimmer laughed. “Breakfast time?” she asked.

“Something simple,” Catra ordered, seeming reluctant as she looked away from Adora’s face to speak to Glimmer. “Can you get us to the dining room and then ask your cooks to make, I dunno, porridge?”

“Sure!” A flash of light, and Catra was gently sitting her down in a chair while Adora’s head spun dizzily.

“Here,” Catra said, soft and warm. “Just rest. Food will be down soon.”

It was. Only a few minutes passed before Glimmer and Bow returned, Glimmer with bowls and silverware, Bow carrying a heavy metal pot.

They were not alone. Angella followed them inside. Her eyes were warm as they fell on Adora, but there were bags beneath them to match Glimmer's. "Adora," she said. "Welcome home."

Adora tried to smile. It sat oddly on her face, so she stopped quickly. "Thanks," she said, looking down at her lap.

There was a pause. Then Angella sighed. "Come, let's eat first. We must talk afterwards."

Catra served Adora a heaping bowl of warm, pale brown slop. Despite looking unappetizing, Adora remembered her delight the first time she'd tried Brightmoon porridge: warm, thick, and rich with sugar and cinnamon, speckled with little pieces of fruit.

She had no appetite today, but Catra was looking at her with that understanding, worried expression in every line of her beautiful face, so Adora reluctantly picked up a spoon and tried a bite. Then she blinked, and the bowl in front of her was empty. She blinked down at the scraped-clean dish before her, then looked up at Catra for explanation.

Catra was smiling down at her, laughter dancing in her eyes. "Guess you *did* have an appetite," she said. "Want seconds?"

Adora did. And half a bowl for thirds.

Finally, she set down the once-more emptied dish and looked up the table at her host. "Thank you, Queen Angella," she said.

Angella smiled at her. "No need to thank me," she said. "Consider it the very beginning of repaying all of Etheria's debt to you."

Adora blinked. "Debt?"

"For ending the war with the Horde."

Hordak's red eyes, wide in a frozen expression of fear as his body slid to the floor with a heavy thud, blood pouring from her blade—

Catra's hand squeezed hers suddenly, and she clutched it tight, as if it might anchor her in a sea of visions. "Yes," she said, blinking away the sight—*Prime, falling at her feet*—and looking back at Angella with what, she hoped, looked something like poise. "Right. That."

Angella looked sad. "I cannot begin to guess at what you're going through," she said. "And I truly hate to ask any more of you—but I must ask one last service, if you can do it. For the sake of those I love."

Adora swallowed, knuckles white around Catra's hand. "What do you need?"

"My husband is currently comatose," Angella said. "Princess Entrapta is trapped on Beast Island. Catra thought you might be able to help them."

Adora blinked. "I can try to rescue Entrapta, but how would I help your husband?"

Catra put her other hand over Adora's. "The Ahamkara got them," she said softly.

—Wings spreading over the Velvet Glove, eyes like stars, mad with gluttony—

Adora blinked and found her head had turned to stare at Catra. She swallowed. "…Which one?"

Catra's jaw twitched. "There was one on Beast Island," she said. "Trapped there. It was the one that—"

—I wish I could save them—

"The one that created She-Ra." Adora's voice was hoarse. "The one that imposed the Sword-Logic on her."

Catra nodded slowly. "King Micah wanted to live long enough to see his wife and daughter again, so he couldn't die on Beast

Island. He went comatose as soon as he saw them. Entrapta wanted to learn everything there was to know about the First Ones, so now she's trapped in front of a console on Beast Island, watching an encyclopedia scroll forever."

"And you think I can help them?"

Catra swallowed. "We know the Anthem Anatheme is paracausal," she said. "And we know it can't reverse itself. We were hoping that a different, equal paracausal power might be able to break the curses."

The bottom dropped out of Adora's stomach. "The Sword-Logic," she murmured. "You need She-Ra."

Catra looked stricken. "No, that's not—"

Adora turned to look at Angella, tears filling her eyes. "I'm so sorry," she whispered. "The Sword of Protection is broken. I can't —"

—This sword will empower you. It will serve as a focus for your runic magic, allowing you to summon She-Ra more readily—

She blinked at Angella. "She-Ra predates the Sword," she said. Her jaw set in determination. "I'll find a way to get She-Ra back," she promised. "I'll save your husband, Queen Angella. And Entrapta. I promise."

She-Ra was what they needed. Adora hadn't known what was happening when she was subsumed by the entity, before—but this time, she did. And she accepted it.

Did she *want* to die, and let She-Ra take her place in this body? Of course not. But since when had that mattered?

-x-x-x-

The Knights who formed the crew of Xivu Arath's flagship gave her a wide berth as she stormed into the bridge, baleful green

light shrouding her in a cloak of power. Her navigator, an ancient neuter-mother, stood to greet her. “Hail, War Incarnate,” she said, three eyes downcast in respect and fear. “You return to us.”

“The hunt was unsuccessful,” Xivu Arath growled, taking her seat in the great chitinous throne at the center of the bridge. “She-Ra has fled once more into her throne-world, and as yet we have no means to penetrate it.”

For a moment there was silence. “Then what are your orders?” the navigator asked at last.

Xivu Arath bared her teeth. “Enough distractions,” she said. “Set a course for Sol. It is time to deal with my heretic of a sister.”

The grand armada slowly turned and began the long journey back to the site of its greatest and only defeat. But Xivu Arath was not her brother. He had been paralyzed by fascination, by curiosity.

When the Light’s champions came before her, she would not hesitate. She needed an outlet for her rage, and unkillable godslayers sounded just *perfect*.

Hope

Chapter Notes

> Adora and Catra talk. About self-worth, and martyrdom, and heroism.

"No," said Catra with sudden fury, grabbing Adora by the collar and turning her around bodily. "I did *not* go through all this just for you to throw it all away!"

Adora felt her eyes brimming with traitorous tears. "Catra—"

"*No!*" Catra buried her face in Adora's chest.

"Mom," said Glimmer suddenly with forced calm, staring at the both of them. "Can you—give us some privacy? For a few minutes."

Angella looked at Adora with a bizarre mixture of gratitude and horror on her face for a moment, before nodding. "I—yes, Glimmer. Of course. I'll just…" She glided silently out of the room and shut the door behind her.

The moment it was closed, Catra started shouting. "You always do this! You always throw yourself in front of the weapon for everyone else, every time! Even when you don't have to!"

"But I *do*—"

"You don't know that! We haven't even started looking for other options!" Catra pulled away, gazing up at her in mingled rage and grief. "You don't have to put yourself last every time, Adora. I can't *watch* you put yourself last every time."

"That's not what this is about!" Adora said, her voice rising in frustration.

"That's *exactly* what this is about! Every time one of your stupid princesses got in trouble, you threw yourself in front of them! Every time I screwed up in training, you tried to take the fall for me! I can't—"

"I'm the only one who can fix this!" Adora shouted. "You said it yourself—only a paracausal force on par with the Anthem Anatheme can undo the dragon's curses. Only She-Ra can—"

"It *isn't worth it*!" Catra screamed, her voice raw. "You're important too! Just as important as Entrapta or Micah!"

"Yes! Because I can help them!"

Catra stopped, staring at her. Adora stared back, both of them breathing heavily.

Catra let go suddenly, like she was pulling her hands from a red-hot pan. "You're more than what you can give away, Adora," she said, and her voice was scratchier than ever, aching and hurt.

"Adora," Glimmer's voice was quiet and hoarse. Adora and Catra both turned to her. Her eyes were red. "I don't want you to—to *become* She-Ra again, like you did when the portal opened."

"It's the only way—" Adora began.

"*Even if* it's the only way to—to save my dad." Glimmer's voice caught on the words, but there was a grimly determined set to her chin. "I can't ask you to do that."

Adora gritted her teeth. "And how is that different from what I'm trying to do?" she asked lowly. "Why is it so much worse when *I* want to give up something to help your whole family—your *kingdom*—than when you want to give up all of that just to save me the trouble."

"Asking you not to *kill yourself* to help people isn't an act of *generosity*," growled Catra. "You. Have. Value. We care about *you*."

“So do Micah and Entrapta,” Adora said implacably. “Look at the numbers—two people for one. And how many more people do you think care about a King and a Princess than some Horde deserter?”

Catra closed her eyes. The lines of her face smoothed out. She took a deep breath and spoke softly. “Do you know why I never came to the Rebellion with you?”

Adora blinked at the non-sequitur. “What? No, I guess not.” Her mind drifted back to the conversation they’d had, just as she was completing her metamorphosis into the Ascendant She-Ra. “You wanted me to… choose you over the Rebellion, I guess?”

Catra made a derisive click with her lips, her eyes still shut. “I *wanted* to feel like you cared about me,” she said.

“I *do* care about you!”

“You care about *everyone*,” said Catra quietly. Her eyes opened, and they glistened as she met Adora’s gaze. “You always have.”

“Since when is *compassion* a bad thing?”

“It’s not.” Catra swallowed reflexively. “But for all that you tried to get Shadow Weaver off my back, for all that you let me get away with sneaking off, or being late for drills, or whatever else I got up to, it was never something you wouldn’t do for anyone else.”

Adora frowed bewilderedly. “What are you getting at, Catra?”

“Sometimes,” Catra said, and her voice broke. “Sometimes a girl just wants to feel special. Valued. *Loved.*”

Adora’s breath froze in her chest.

“All I ever wanted was to feel like I mattered to you,” Catra continued mercilessly, tears springing from her eyes. “Like I was important to you.”

"You *were*—"

"More than every other faceless Horde soldier. More even than Lonnie, Kyle, or Rogelio. Like we were *friends*, and that I wasn't just the burden Shadow Weaver kept saying I was. I eventually believed it—thought I had that." She scrubbed at her cheeks with a hand, wiping her teary eyes. "Then you dropped me on our first mission and went to the Rebellion."

"I *had* to," Adora said in a small voice. "People were *suffering*."

"I know," said Catra, barely above a whisper. "I wanted to feel like I mattered more to you than those faceless *people*, who you and I had never met, who had abandoned both of us, and every other cadet, to the mercies of the Horde as babies. I *needed* you to care more about me than you did about the parents who abandoned me, and you, and everyone else we knew." She took a deep breath and let it out shuddering. "Selfish, I know. But that's me—selfish to the bone."

"You're not—"

"Adora, I'm not being self-deprecating," Catra snapped with sudden energy, her eyes snapping wide, tail lashing. "*Yes*, I'm selfish. Compared to what *you* are, I'm proud of it!"

Adora reared back defensively. "What's that supposed to mean!"

It means that the universe does not run on martyrdom.

"It means that I'm not watching you sacrifice yourself again!" Catra's voice was nearly drowned out by the sudden murmur in Adora's ears.

Adora froze. Her eyes stared out at nothing. "…She-Ra?"

"What?"

Yes. The *thing* inside her stretched luxuriously, as if waking from a restful nap. *Your arguing would wake the dead—and I am not*

dead.

"Adora, what's going on?" Catra's voice was panicked. "What's happening? I'm sorry, I'm sorry for everything, just *please* don't go back to—"

You'd best reassure her, said She-Ra, sounding amused. Her voice was like a deeper version of Adora's, but layered beneath it she could hear Mara, Aleeri, Nessa, and ever other She-Ra she could half-remember having been.

"I'm still me," Adora said aloud, cutting off Catra's panicked stream of apologies. "I just—I'm hearing She-Ra. In my head."

Yes, this is rather new, isn't it? She-Ra seemed to look around, or do the mental equivalent of it—casting around her senses within the confines of Adora's psyche. *You're the first, well,* ***me*** *since Mara's wish, so I suppose there would be some growing pains.*

"Can you take control of me again?" Adora asked.

"No," Catra hissed, but the tone of her voice wasn't angry—it was the agonized gasp of someone being stabbed.

Mm. Perhaps, if I tried very hard. It is the nature of the Sword-Logic to overcome the impossible. But this is your body, not mine—you have the home field advantage, so to speak. Either of us might emerge victorious.

Adora swallowed. "What if I gave it to you?" she asked, trying her hardest to ignore the wounded sound Catra made. "Would you break the curses on Entrapta and King Micah?"

She-Ra was silent for a moment. Adora felt the gentle cloud of her thoughts drifting within the atmosphere of her mind condense and shrink, curling up into something opaque and difficult to read from the outside. *…Yes,* she said at last. *Yes, I would. Do you want that? Do you want to give yourself up to heal Entrapta and Micah?*

Yes. The word was on Adora's lips, but unbidden her eyes drifted down to Catra.

As Adora and She-Ra spoke, Catra had sat down heavily on a vacant cot. She wasn't looking at Adora anymore. Adora had seen Catra after losing her armies, after losing friends, after losing entire campaigns, but she had only seen her look this *defeated* once before—in Hordak's laboratory, as She-Ra pulled her sword from Shadow-Weaver's corpse.

The word remained frozen on her tongue as she stared down at Catra. Catra who had never wanted anything but to be valued. To be loved.

"Catra," Adora said softly.

Catra's head snapped up, fear and desperate hope on her face. "What?"

"Did you mean it?"

"Did I—what? What are you—oh." The slits of Catra's eyes went nearly round. Then her face set. "Yes. I love you, Adora. I always have." She swallowed hard. "If that's not enough, then at least I'll know."

I love you. The words rang Adora's head like a hammer in a bell, bouncing around the inside of her skull until the drowned out all else. *Yes* remained frozen on the tip of her tongue.

Then, slowly, it began to melt back. "No," she said softly. "No, She-Ra—I don't want that. I can't."

Good, said She-Ra, sounding satisfied. *Then you are what I can no longer be.*

Adora blinked. "What?"

"What?" Catra asked, staring at her with round eyes.

"Not you—"

She-Ra was meant to be a banner, not a sword. A rallying cry. A living symbol, not a martyr. She-Ra sounded almost triumphant. *In spite of everything—in spite of the best efforts of Light Hope, of two dragons, of the Horde and the Hive and even whatever I now am—you remain. Pure. You are not* meant *to die in glorious sacrifice, She-Ra. You are meant to* live*. She-Ra is meant to be a symbol of hope, not a burnt offering on the pyre of need.*

Adora's eyes pricked. "But how can I be a symbol of *hope* if I can't even save two people from a problem that Mara—that *we*—caused?"

That's the point. This will be my first and only lesson to you, young She-Ra. Hope is not something you find by providence. It's not something given to you by fate and chance. Hope is where you plant your flag. You do not find hope—you make *it. In the darkest night you reach out and you drag the Sun to the horizon yourself if necessary.*

Adora's hands were shaking. "What do you mean, your *only* lesson?"

Just what I said. She-Ra laughed, free and bright. *I am a stitched-together mass of fragmented consciousnesses. Those consciousnesses I now release. You are not the bearer of She-Ra. You* are *She-Ra. I am just your memory of her.*

"I'm not going to let *you* die to save me the trouble!" Adora exclaimed.

Don't you get it yet, She-Ra? No one's dying today. Because you're not dying.

"And I'm you," Adora said, and blinked as the two halves became whole in the space between heartbeats.

Catra and Glimmer were both staring at her. "Adora?" Catra asked hesitantly.

Adora blinked at her stupidly for a moment, and then felt a giddy smile cross her face. “Catra,” she whispered. “I love you too.” She held her right hand up. “And I’m still Adora. I always will be.

“*For the honor of Grayskull!*”

A year later, and a hundred thousand light-years away, a man woke with a start. Blinking the sleep out of his eyes, he swung his legs over the side of his bed and crossed the small one-room apartment to gaze out his window. His hands automatically found the mask resting on his end table and fixed it over his face as he stared up at the marble-white orb hovering over the grandest and last city in the world.

For five years he had remained, silent and hidden, struggling with his own despair and the quaking terror that plagued his dreams. But today that was all changed, for today he had dreamed something different.

A being of starlight had stared across the vast space between galaxies and seen their gentle place, and the Guardians who ringed it in spears. And instead of seeing a heresy to be crushed, or a resource to exploit, or a territory to claim, this creature had seen what every Guardian had sworn to protect.

No more running, said the woman in the stars, and the Traveler listened. *No more delays. Hope is where we plant our flag. Today, our flag is planted.*

The Speaker let out a long exhale and turned to find the shabby old robe he had not worn in half a decade. At long last, he had something to say worth hearing. No more of *The Traveler will leave us.*

Now, the refrain was *The Traveler stands with us. We are not alone.*

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